The Case Against Dualism

Phil 101 · Day 14

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Where we are

Dualism

Tuesday we set out two old and famous arguments for dualism.

- The flying man: he knows he exists without knowing his body does.
- Descartes's distinction: I can clearly and distinctly conceive mind without body.

Both arguments had the same problem. They start with something about knowledge, and end with something about how things are, and that's messy because the principles you need fail in cases where you don't know about an identity.

Today

Today is the case against, and it starts from a much more concrete question.

If your mind is not a physical thing, how does it move your arm?

Elisabeth

Elisabeth of Bohemia

At the time she started writing to Descartes, she was a twenty-four year old minor princess.

Her family were exiled royalty living in The Hague. Her father had lost a kingdom, or at least a principality, and then died in a war.

She read the *Meditations*, and in May 1643 she wrote to Descartes.

They corresponded for the rest of his life. He later dedicated the *Principles of Philosophy* to her.

The question

> **i** Elisabeth, 6 May 1643
>
> Given that the soul of a human being is only a *thinking* substance, how can it affect the bodily spirits, in order to bring about voluntary actions?

Note here that I'm using the rather free translation that Jonathan Bennett made. His translations are not particularly popular among real scholars, because he aims to capture the ideas in readable, contemporary prose, and this sometimes misleads you as to the details of the original text.

But it's 101, we're just getting started, we can use the easy-to-read translations.

Why it is hard

Elisabeth

It seems that how a thing moves depends solely on (i) how much it is pushed, (ii) the manner in which it is pushed, or (iii) the surface-texture and shape of the thing that pushes it. The first two of those require *contact* between the two things, and the third requires that the causally active thing be extended. Your notion of the soul entirely excludes extension, and it appears to me that an immaterial thing can't possibly *touch* anything else.

The structure of her argument

She doesn't deny anything Descartes has argued for. Indeed she grants, at least for the sake of argument, that there are souls.

She also grants that it thinks and isn't extended. She just asks him to say how it does this.

And she uses *his own physics* to do it. Those three ways a thing can move are Descartes's.

iClicker QUIZ

Elisabeth's objection turns on the claim that moving a body requires

A. a soul
B. contact, or else being extended
C. God's cooperation
D. the pineal gland

The reply

Three primitive notions

Descartes answers that there are a few basic notions that everything else is built from.

For material things, bodies, the basic notion is **extension**.

For immaterial things, souls, the basic notion is **thought**.

And then he adds a somewhat harder to understand third:

> ℹ Descartes, 21 May 1643
>
> And finally, for the soul and the body together, only the notion of **their union**, on which depends the notion of the soul's power to move the body and the body's power to act on the soul.

Descartes' Reply

> **Descartes**
>
> I observe next that all secure, disciplined human knowledge consists only in keeping these notions well apart from one another, and applying each of them only to the things that it is right for.

That is, the union of mind and body is basic, and not to be understood in terms of properties of minds or properties of bodies.

Asking how it works in terms of extension, or thought, is applying the wrong notion, and you were bound to go wrong.

Is that an answer?

Every theory has something it treats as basic and doesn't explain further, so it's not like it should be ruled out straight away.

But Elisabeth had asked *how*, and the answer is that how-questions don't apply here. That's bound to be unsatisfying.

Pressing

Elisabeth, 10 June 1643

But I've never been able to conceive of 'what is immaterial' in any way except as 'what is not material', and *that* can't enter into causal relations with matter!

Elisabeth

I would find it easier to concede matter and extension to the soul than to concede that an immaterial thing could move and be moved by a body.

Counting the costs

Elisabeth is doing something here that has become much more standard in contemporary philosophy than it was in her time.

She is agreeing that we are facing hard problems, and every option will have a downside.

So the question becomes not *Is this view obviously good*, but *Is this view less bad than the others?*, i.e., *Does it require you to accept less costly things?*.

Elisabeth is saying that accepting immaterial things moving bodies is a more costly belief than accepting that minds can be extended.

The admission

> Descartes, 28 June 1643
>
> It seems to me that the human mind *can't* conceive the soul's distinctness from the body and its union with the body, conceiving them very clearly and both at the same time. That is because this requires one to conceive them as one single thing and at the same time as two things, which is contradictory.

This feels like he's giving up a lot!

The advice

So what does he recommend?

> **Descartes**
>
> What teaches us how to conceive the soul's union with the body is the ordinary course of life and conversation, and *not* meditating or studying things that exercise the imagination.

Imagination is, according to Descartes:

- Useful for understanding the metaphysical nature of minds and bodies, taken separately;
- Not useful for understanding how minds and bodies interact.

This is not a stable position.

More advice

> **Descartes**
>
> I never spend more than a few hours a day in the thoughts involving the imagination, or more than a few hours a year on thoughts that involve the intellect alone.

We're getting very close to Descartes telling Elisabeth to not worry her pretty little head about it!

The modern version

Causal closure

Elisabeth's worry has a descendant. Physics looks **causally closed**: every physical event that has a cause has a sufficient physical cause.

Your arm going up is a physical event.

If it already has a sufficient physical cause, then either the mind is one of the physical causes, or it is doing nothing.

Three hundred years of science have made the first disjunct more attractive, by steadily finding physical causes where they were wanted. Again, think about how we used to think we needed some special new force, the vital force, to explain how living things grow, and now we think this isn't needed.

Physicalism

The identity theory

> **Berger**
>
> Mental states are identical to—or the same things as—states of our brains.

Minds aren't caused by bodies, or correlated with bodies. Rather, they **are** bodies.

The identity here is like the identity between lightning and electrical discharge or water and H_2O.

We could know that lightning struck without knowing that there was an electrical discharge, but that wouldn't prove that the identity claim is wrong.

Can we clearly and distinctly perceive lightning without electrical discharge, or water without H_2O? Maybe!

It was a scientific finding, and the identity theorist expects pain to go the same way.

Why that answers Elisabeth

If your decision to raise your arm just *is* a brain state, there is no gap for anything to cross.

The interaction problem was a problem about how two things, material bodies and immaterial minds, play well together. If they are just one thing, that's not a problem.

Multiple realizability

There is a common objection to the identity theory, what's called the multiple reailizability objection.

Berger

It seems our mental states are what philosophers call 'multiply realizable': different sorts of physical systems can all exhibit the same types of mental states.

An octopus has nothing much like our brain. If it can be in pain anyway, pain can't be identical to the human arrangement.

Functionalism

> **Berger**
>
> Mental states should be understood in terms of their function, that is, their characteristic causes and effects.

Pain is whatever is caused by damage and causes wincing and avoidance.

In us it's neurons. In an octopus, it's something else. In a robot, *maybe* a circuit. (Or more likely not; do we really think robots feel pain?)

This is a fairly popular view, more or less orthodoxy when I was a student though ore contested now. It's why it's respectable to wonder whether a machine could think; it is coherent to ask whether machines have states that play the causal role for them that beliefs play for us.

The hard problem is still, indeed, hard

This might just be a product of it being the mainstream view when I was a student, but I think this is a pretty plausible account of what it is for a physical state to be a *belief*.

But it's much less clear that it works for *pain*.

Pains do have a functional role. But they also feel a certain way. It seems very plausible that a robot could have sensors that play the same functional role to do with damage detection and mitigation, and not feel anything.

Which is why property dualism keeps feeling plausible: you can be a functionalist about thought and still think consciousness is left over.

Half Time Summary

The scorecard

All the views have costs, and like Elisabeth suggested, the best move next might be to think about which of them is less costly.

- Dualist views explain various puzzles, but have troubles with interactions.
- Identity theory does well with interaction, but has trouble with cross-kind comparisons (e.g., us vs octopi vs aliens vs machines).
- Functionalism does well with with the things we have in common with machines, and not with the things that separate us.

Every position here is somebody's considered view, and there are notable downsides to each.

No tidy ending

Berger

The mind-body problem thus remains one of the enduring puzzles of human thought.

What you should have a start on is not an answer but a guide: what are the moves, what are their strengths and weaknesses, what questions do they answer and what do they set aside?

Going forward

Dates

- **Module Quiz 2** opens after class, on Lectures 10 to 14, due Sunday 1 November.
- **Short Answer 2** is due Friday 23 October.
- No class Tuesday: Fall Study Break.

When we come back

We change subject on the 22nd. The second half of the course is on how to live well, individually and collectively.